

3.5 Urban and rural distribution of population

At the 1971 Census of Sri Lanka 2,848,116 persons were enumerated in urban areas while 9,841,781 persons were enumerated in rural areas, which included the estates. Thus 22.4 percent of the total population was categorised as Urban.

Table 3.5 shows the urban-rural distribution of population since 1901. It can be seen that the total urban population as well as the urban proportion of the total population has increased steadily except during the short period 1946 to 1953. The sharp rise between 1953 and 1963 could be attributed mainly to the inclusion of Town Councils into the urban category.²

TABLE 3.5 : DISTRIBUTION OF URBAN AND RURAL POPULATION IN SRI LANKA FOR CENSUS YEARS 1901 TO 1971

Census Year	Urban and Rural areas		Urban Areas		Rural Areas	
	Population ('000)	Percentage	Population ('000)	Percentage	Population ('000)	Percentage
1901	3,565.9	100.0	414.0	11.6	3,151.9	88.4
1911	4,106.4	100.0	543.0	13.2	3,563.4	86.8
1921	4,498.6	100.0	637.9	14.2	3,860.7	85.8
1931	5,306.9	100.0	737.3	13.9	4,569.6	86.1
1946	6,657.3	100.0	1,023.0	15.4	5,634.3	84.6
1953	8,097.9	100.0	1,239.1	15.3	6,858.8	84.7
1963	10,582.0	100.0	2,016.3	19.1	8,565.7	80.9
1971	12,689.9	100.0	2,848.1	22.4	9,841.8	77.6

The growth in urban population between 1963 and 1971 is also due mainly to the accretion of new areas into the urban category rather than to the increase of population by natural increase or migration within the existing urban areas. This fact is clearly seen in Table 3.6, which compares the population of those areas which were classified as urban in both 1963 and 1971.

TABLE 3.6 : URBAN POPULATION AS AT THE CENSUSES OF 1963 AND 1971

	1963		1971		Per inc 196
	Population	Percentage of total	Population	Percentage of total	
(a) Total (urban and rural)	10,582,064	100.0	12,689,897	100.0	1
(b) All urban areas	2,016,285	19.0	2,848,116	22.4	4
(c) All areas which were classified as urban in both 1963 and 1971	2,016,285	19.0	2,444,919	19.3	2

1 The classification into urban and rural sectors at the census has been based on the administrative sub-division for local government purposes. At the 1971 Census those areas administered by Municipal Councils, Urban Councils and Town Councils were considered as Urban.

2 At the 1963 and earlier censuses, only Municipal and Urban Council areas were classified as Urban because Town Councils were not in existence at these censuses.